

Cutting Salt and Sugar - Hawker and Home Tips

Salt and sugar can creep in through sauces, drinks, soups, snacks, and ready-made foods. You do not need a perfect diet; you need a few repeatable choices that lower your usual intake.

Hawker ordering tips

Start with the parts you can control. Ask for less gravy, less sauce, and soup on the side. Choose wholegrain options when available. Add vegetables so the meal is not mostly rice, noodles, or fried items.

Meal situation	Ask for	Why it helps
Rice or noodle stall	Less gravy or sauce	Reduces hidden salt and sugar
Soup dish	Soup on the side	Lets you taste without finishing all the soup
Economy rice	More vegetables, one protein	Improves balance and fullness
Drinks stall	Kosong or siew dai	Cuts added sugar

For laksa, nasi lemak, or other rich meals, keep portions sensible and balance the rest of the day with lighter meals. If you enjoy sauces, dip lightly instead of pouring them over the whole plate.

Home cooking habits

Taste before adding salt, sauce, or sweetener. Use garlic, ginger, chilli, lime, vinegar, herbs, spices, and toasted sesame for flavour. Add vegetables to noodles, fried rice, omelettes, and soups. When using bottled sauces, start with half your usual amount and add more only if needed.

Keep sweet drinks and sweet snacks out of daily reach. Put fruit, plain yoghurt, or nuts where they are easy to see. If you bake or make desserts, reduce sweetness gradually so the family palate adjusts.

Reading labels

Labels help you compare similar products. Look for words such as sodium, salt, sugar, syrup, honey, and sweetened. Choose lower-sodium and lower-sugar versions when the taste and price work for you. Compare per serving and per 100 g or per 100 ml, because serving sizes can differ.

Make change gradual

Your taste buds can adapt. Try one change for two weeks before adding another. If your usual kopi is sweet, order siew dai. If your usual sauce habit is heavy, ask for sauce at the side. Small changes repeated daily matter more than a strict plan you cannot keep.

Key points

- Ask for less gravy, soup on the side, and less sauce at hawker stalls.
- Choose wholegrain options and add vegetables when available.
- Use herbs, spices, lime, vinegar, garlic, and ginger for flavour at home.
- Compare labels for sodium and sugar.
- Reduce sweetness and saltiness gradually so the habit lasts.

When to talk to a health professional

Speak to a doctor or dietitian if you have high blood pressure, kidney disease, heart disease, diabetes, swelling, or you have been advised to follow a personalised eating plan.

This guide is sample content written for the LiveWell Coach workshop. It is general information, not medical advice. If you have symptoms or a health condition, speak to a doctor.